time walks some of my thoughts on this subject with minister (economic) S.C. Tripathi (IAS 1968 Uttar Pradesh, who later retired as petroleum secretary). I continued exchanging my views on this and other subjects of common interest with him, whenever we played golf at the Delhi Golf Club. I had similar chats with former secretary, R&AW, Vikram Sood, who, like me, had settled in Gurgaon after his retirement.



Based on my twenty-six years' experience of working in the 'Department' (a term normally used for the R&AW by insiders), I decided to write two books on subjects of significant national importance. Because of a number of reasons – both official and personal – I could not undertake these projects earlier. When the time came for writing the first book on Sikkim, May 2011 onwards, my wife's leiomyosarcoma was detected, and my time and energy were entirely devoted to her treatment. After the initial positive response, the cancer resurfaced. She faced the ailment boldly and there was no regret or pain on her face till the last moment, which came in January 2017.

With the book on Sikkim published in 2018, it was time to think about the next one. Initially, I had apprehensions as to how the average Indian would react to the contents of such a book. Most of the people I knew, including some close friends, were unwilling to look beyond Bhindranwale in pinning the blame for Operation Blue Star, without caring to know who had created that monster and most importantly, for what purpose. Efforts were also being made to describe the anti-Sikh pogrom of Delhi and elsewhere as a natural consequence of Indira Gandhi's assassination by her two Sikh security guards. However, certain developments that came to my notice 2017 onwards led me to think that in so far as informed public opinion about the 1984 anti-Sikh pogrom was concerned, things were changing for the better. The subject was being actively discussed on various television channels, and major newspapers carried editorials and lead articles critical of the role played by some